THE LOWER DECKS

Most of the ship's crew slept in hammocks slung from the beams of the gun decks. Each man had 53cm (21in) of sleeping space. At meal times the crew messed in the same area at tables that were also suspended from the beams. The gun ports provided the only natural light and fresh air, but these were often shut to keep out the waves. The areas below the water-line were even more dank and gloomy, but they were actually the safest place in a battle and thus suitable for storing gunpowder. The ship's surgeon had his dispensary on the orlop deck below the lower gun deck and this was where wounded men were brought to be operated on.



Lower gun deck
The recoil of each gun was controlled by a thick breeching rope. It allowed the gun to move back enough to be in-board of the gun port, so it could be reloaded.

Middle gun deck
The wide low gun decks not only housed the guns but also provided the eating and sleeping space *(below)* for most of the ship's crew.





On-board food
The ship's galley, with the cast-iron Brodie stove, was on the middle gun deck. The sailors ate their rations, including dry "hard tack" biscuits, from wooden bowls or their own plates.





Mess kid
This was a kind of bucket made by the ship's cooper. It was used by one member of a mess to collect the food for his messmates from the galley.



Bosun's storeroom
This storeroom housed stores to repair the rigging. The bosun was in charge of the deck crew and responsible for the cordage and anchors.



Carpenter's storeroom
The upkeep and repair of the wooden fabric of the ship was a daily activity on board. The carpenter's storeroom was well forward in the hold.